Policy & Strategy Lab

Workbook 1: Problem Framing

Participant	
Name	
Case (problem statement)	
Decision-making role and decision	
Pod	

How to use this workbook

Each worksheet applies one day's anchor tool to your own case. Complete it during the session and finish it in your independent time. Keep earlier versions: revision is credited, so record what changed and why in the feedback box at the end of each worksheet. Tag every substantive claim in your Analyst's Ledger as fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

Competencies practised in this workbook: A1, A2, A3, A4.

Using AI tools. You may use AI tools to suggest structures, rival explanations or improvements to your writing. You may not use AI output as evidence. Every fact, figure, citation and description of an institution must come from a source you have checked.

Worksheet 1.1: Sorting your candidate cases

Day 1: Problems, clients and decisions. Anchor tool: Problem, symptom, cause and solution sort.

Purpose. Separate what you believe about each candidate case into problems, symptoms, causes and solutions, and test whether anyone could act on it.

In brief.

- Most first drafts of a problem statement contain a cause or a solution. Finding them is the first skill.
- A problem is a gap, for a defined group, that someone has the authority to close.
- Name the decision-maker and the decision early: they tell you what to analyse.
- Public problems are contested. Say whose definition you are adopting.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). Madhyapur. Candidate: waste segregation. Statements: most households hand over mixed waste (problem); the landfill is close to full (symptom); crews tip separated bags into one compartment (candidate cause); give every household two bins (solution). Problem statement: most households in Madhyapur's residential wards do not hand over waste separated into the streams the 2016 rules require. Role: Municipal Commissioner. Decision: which compliance strategy to fund next financial year.

Instructions.

1. List three candidate problems you might work on, one line each.
2. For each, write five statements you believe to be true about it.
3. Sort every statement into problem, symptom, cause or solution.
4. Rewrite each candidate as a problem statement with no cause or solution in it.
5. Name a role that could act on each, and the decision it faces.

Statement sort (complete one for each candidate)

Statement	Problem, symptom, cause or solution?	Why

Candidate summary

Candidate	Problem statement (no cause, no solution)	Decision-making role	Decision it faces

A thinker for your case: Rittel and Webber. Whose definition of the problem are you adopting, and what would count as solved?

My answer, in one sentence

Reflection.

1. Which candidate had the most solutions hidden in it, and why?
2. For which candidate was it hardest to name someone with authority to act? What does that tell you about it as a four-week case?
3. Rittel and Webber: whose definition of the problem were you adopting in each candidate?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ No problem statement contains a cause or a solution.
- ☐ Each candidate names an affected group and a place.
- ☐ Each candidate names a role, not the government in general.
- ☐ Every statement is tagged in your Analyst's Ledger.

Hand in. Worksheet 1.1 with three sorted candidates and a provisional choice, by the start of Day 2.

Before the next session. Finish Worksheet 1.1. For the candidate you are most likely to choose, open two public data sources and note what each covers, at what level (state, district or city) and for which year. Bring both to Day 2. About 45 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why

Worksheet 1.2: Problem Definition Canvas and Case Approval Form

Day 2: Defining the problem. Anchor tool: Problem Definition Canvas.

Purpose. Define your case precisely enough to analyse and act on, and confirm it is workable in four weeks.

In brief.

- A precise statement names who, where, which institution, what gap, compared with what, and who could act.
- Scope is a decision: say what you leave out and why.
- Every problem can be framed several ways. Adopt one deliberately and record the others.
- Define success by what changes for people, not only by what is spent or supplied.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). See the Madhyapur canvas on the Day 2 slides. Problem statement: most households in Madhyapur's residential wards hand over waste unseparated, contrary to the 2016 rules; the Municipal Commissioner must decide which compliance strategy to fund next financial year.

Instructions.

1. Fill the nine boxes of the canvas for your chosen case.
2. Run your problem statement through 5W1H and fix any vague word.
3. Record two other framings and say which you adopt, and why.
4. Score your case on the five quick tests and fix any failure.
5. Complete the Case Approval Form and submit it today.

Problem Definition Canvas

Box	Your entry
Affected group	
Place	
Institution	
Current condition (with source and year)	
Desired condition (and the rule, target or norm behind it)	
Decision-maker and decision	
Why it matters	
Out of scope, with reasons	
Measure of success	

Competing framings

Who frames it this way	How they would state the problem	Adopted? Why or why not

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Case Approval Form

Field	Entry
Problem statement	
Population, place and institution	
Decision-making role and decision	
Why the problem matters	
Public data source 1 (opened and checked)	
Public data source 2 (opened and checked)	
Published qualitative or field-based source	
Ethical or access concerns	
Three candidate questions	

A thinker for your case: Amartya Sen. Are you measuring access to a resource, or what people are actually able to do with it?

My answer, in one sentence

Reflection.

1. Sen: is your measure of success about a resource or about what people can do? Rewrite it if needed.
2. What did you leave out of scope that you are most tempted to bring back in?
3. Which of the five quick tests did your case come closest to failing?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ The statement names group, place, institution and period.
- ☐ Current condition has a source and a year.
- ☐ At least two items are out of scope, with reasons.

- ☐ Two competing framings are recorded.
- ☐ The Case Approval Form is complete.

Hand in. Canvas and Case Approval Form by the end of Day 2. Provisional approval is returned by Day 3.

Before the next session. Revise your canvas after the gallery walk. Find the published qualitative or field-based source the Case Approval Form asks for, such as an audit report, social audit, committee report or field study, and note its two most relevant findings. About 45 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why